R&D | RetailPulse

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Insights Analyst Guide

> **In simple words**
>
> This guide shows how an Insights Analyst thinks and works: from data to information to insight to action. It also gives the step roadmap with purpose and result.

1. Your lane: Insights Analyst

Companies now split analyst work into two lanes. **Insights Analysts** talk to the business, tell stories with data and drive decisions. **Analytics Engineers** build pipelines and production-level data models. You chose the first lane. Your projects, resume and learning should all point there.

	Insights Analyst (you)	Analytics Engineer (not now)
Main question	What does this mean and what should we do?	How do we make the data reliable and automatic?
Talks to	Managers and business teams	Data engineers and analysts
Tools	SQL, Power BI, Excel, storytelling	dbt, Airflow, cloud, pipelines
Output	Insights, dashboards, recommendations	Clean models and pipelines

2. From data to action (the ladder)

Level	Example format	Who stops here
Data	Dairy sales: 1,200 units on Monday	Beginners
Information	Dairy WAPE is [X]%	Junior analysts
Insight	Dairy WAPE is [X] points above overall, mostly after holidays	Good analysts
Action	Do not copy last week's holiday sales into next week's order	Insights analysts

Numbers in this table are placeholders. Use your real results.

3. Five-step habit

1. **Ask:** What decision does this support?
2. **Check:** Is the data clean and complete?
3. **Analyze:** Compare groups and periods.
4. **Explain:** Why? Test a hypothesis. Say 'likely' if unproven.
5. **Recommend:** Action, owner, priority, how to measure.

4. Skills map

Need now	Good to have	Skip for now
SQL (joins, CTEs, window functions)	Basic statistics (M.Sc Maths helps)	Airflow, dbt, Spark
Power BI and DAX basics	Excel pivots and lookups	Cloud data platforms
Business storytelling	A/B testing basics	Machine learning models
Stakeholder communication	Python for charts	Production data pipelines

5. Roadmap: purpose and result of each step

Step	Purpose	Result
1 Folders and tools	Keep work organized	Folder tree, PostgreSQL ready
2 Load data	Get data into SQL	5 tables with correct row counts
3 Data checks	Find problems early	List of issues and how they are handled
4 Holiday flag table	Avoid double counting	One row per store and date
5 Baseline forecast	Create a guess to compare	Baseline A and B in a view
6 Error table	Measure the miss	Fact table with error, excess, shortfall, flags
7 Analysis Q1 to Q12	Find where, when, which way	CSV outputs and an insight log
8 Power BI model	Make exploration easy	Star model, measures that match SQL
9 Dashboard pages	Show the story	5 pages with headline titles
10 Insights and actions	Turn findings into advice	6+ insight cards, action table
11 Report	Explain to managers	8 to 10 page report
12 Presentation	Persuade	8-slide deck and 2-minute story
13 Portfolio	Be found by recruiters	GitHub repo, README, resume lines

6. Common mistakes

- Showing numbers without a comparison or an action.
- Presenting a cause as a fact when it is only a guess.
- Inventing money values when the data has no cost.
- Too many charts. Fewer, clearer charts win.
- Using jargon with managers.

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